

Apparent voice mismatches in K'iche' ellipsis: non-distinctness, argument structure, and syntactic feature composition

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Abstract: This paper investigates apparent voice mismatches in TP ellipsis in the Mayan language K'iche'. Antecedents of TP ellipsis in K'iche' can contain a verb in the so-called absolutive antipassive (AP) form in contexts where the elided verb must be active transitive. I argue that the K'iche' AP differs from the active transitive not in Voice specification, but in that it completely lacks the internal argument. The resulting mismatch bears directly on the formulation of the Syntactic Identity Condition on ellipsis and illustrates how ellipsis can be used to probe the feature composition of syntactic structures, including those associated with voice and argument structure. I show that the K'iche' facts are compatible with an approach to ellipsis that requires featural non-distinctness between the antecedent and the elided material, but not with the various stricter approaches which require syntactic identity. I further argue that purported restrictions on argument structure mismatches in ellipsis reduce to cases involving feature clashes. Finally, I consider the implications of these findings for theories of syntactic features. If the SIC argued for here is correct, privative features are necessary, but cannot be the only type of feature employed by the syntax.

Keywords: ellipsis, syntactic identity, voice mismatch, argument structure, syntactic features, K'iche' Maya

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1 Introduction

Deletion of material in K'iche' (K'ichean, Mayan) is observed in *xow*-focus (1) and *are*-focus constructions (2), as well as in typical sluicing environments (3).¹

- (1) Ri ak'al na nojel ta q'ij k-ø-tz'ib'-an-ik, xaq xow we je'lik
DET child NEG every IRR day NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP-IV PRT just DET pretty
taq tzij <k-ø-u-tz'ib'-aj / *k-ø-tz'ib'-an-ik>.
PL word NPST-ERG3SG-ABS3SG-write-TV NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP-IV
'The boy doesn't (generally) write every day, just poetry.'
- (2) Ri ak'al k-ø-tz'ib'-an ronojel q'ij, are ri je'lik taq tzij no
DET child NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP every day EMPH DET pretty PL word NO
<k-ø-u-tz'ib'-aj / *k-ø-tz'ib'-an-ik>.
NPST-ERG3SG-ABS3SG-write-TV NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP-IV
'The boy writes every day, but poetry, he doesn't.'
- (3) Ri ak'al k-ø-tz'ib'-an ronojel q'ij, pero na wetam ta jas
DET child NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP every day but NEG know IRR what
uwach <k-ø-u-tz'ib'-aj / *k-ø-tz'ib'-an-ik>.
kind NPST-ERG3SG-ABS3SG-write-TV NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP-IV
'The boy writes every day, but I don't know what.'

In this paper, I focus on the *xow*-focus phenomenon in (1), returning to classical sluicing briefly in section 3.4, where I undertake a comparison of K'iche' with the closely related language Kaqchikel. The main novel observation I will focus on is the following: Antecedents of TP ellipsis in K'iche' can contain a verb in the so-called absolutive antipassive (AP) form in contexts where the elided verb must be active transitive. This can be observed in (1)–(3): The overt verb is AP, yet the elided verbal complex (in angled brackets throughout) must be active transitive given the presence of the direct object outside the ellipsis site. As we will see, direct objects are disallowed with AP verb forms. Hence, non-elliptical versions of the sentences in (1)–(3) are only possible if the second verb is active transitive, but not if it is AP. In descriptive terms, this constitutes an apparent voice mismatch (antipassive-active) between the antecedent and the material in the ellipsis site (e.g., Mondloch 1981).² Mismatches of this kind have been argued to be impossible in the previous literature on ellipsis (Ross 1969, Merchant 2013, Chung 2006, 2013, Rudin 2019, a.o.).

¹Abbreviations in glosses are as follows: 1, 2, 3 – 1st, 2nd, 3rd person, ABS – absolutive, ACT – active, AF – agent focus, AP – absolutive antipassive, CL – clitic, CLF – classifier, DET – determiner, EMPH – emphatic particle, ERG – ergative, EXS – existential, IMP – imperative, IRR – irrealis particle, IV – intransitive verb, NEG – negation, NPST – non-past tense, PL – plural, POSS – possessive, PRT – particle, PST – past tense, REFL – reflexive RN – relational noun, SG – singular, TV – transitive verb.

²It is impossible to construct examples where the mismatch is the other way around (antipassive-active), for independent reasons. Since the AP lacks an internal argument, the only argument that can be questioned/focused is the external argument. However, if the external argument is questioned/focused, the verb in such contexts must be in so-called Agent Focus voice, see section 2.

Hence, the mismatches in (1)–(3) are pertinent in the context of research on well-formedness conditions for ellipsis. There are two pressing questions. First, what is the exact syntactic structure of the K’iche’ AP (as compared to the active transitive)? And second, what is the syntactic relationship between the antecedent and the ellipsis site, such that it can accommodate these facts? In answering the first question, I will argue that the apparent active/AP voice mismatch in K’iche’ is, in fact, a transitivity alternation, with the AP form being identical to the active transitive verb form, except for the complete lack of an internal argument. This will lead me to argue, in response to the second question, that the mismatch observed in K’iche’ can be accounted for under an approach to ellipsis which requires featural non-distinctness between the antecedent and elided material (Ranero 2021, Ranero and Royer 2024; see also Chomsky 1965), but not under the various stricter approaches which require syntactic identity between the two (e.g., Merchant 2013, Chung 2013, Rudin 2019, a.o.).

More broadly, I argue that ellipsis offers a window into the feature composition of syntactic structure. If the well-formedness of ellipsis is sensitive to feature clashes between antecedents and ellipsis sites, then ellipsis patterns can reveal aspects of syntactic representations that are not always apparent on the surface. I illustrate this by comparing the K’iche’ AP with its counterpart in the closely related language Kaqchikel: despite their superficial similarities, only the K’iche’ AP participates in the relevant mismatch under ellipsis. This contrast suggests that the two constructions differ in their underlying feature composition, a conclusion that is independently supported by differences in causativization patterns. Thus, beyond its implications for theories of ellipsis, the present study argues that ellipsis can be used to probe the feature encoding of voice and other syntactic phenomena.

The paper is organized as follows: In section 2, I present some background facts about K’iche’ grammar, with the aim of making the rest of the paper easier to follow.

Section 3 presents the main proposal of the paper. First, in section 3.1, I show that the *xow*-construction involves genuine TP ellipsis. Section 3.2 demonstrates that the K’iche’ AP is an intransitive verb form, which differs from the active transitive not in voice but in argument structure. I argue that the structure of the AP is parallel to the active transitive form, except for a complete lack of internal argument. As we will see, when the categorizer *v* has a [D] feature (selects for an internal argument) and VoiceACT has an [ERG](ative) case feature, the resulting verb is active transitive. If those features are absent, the resulting verb form is AP. In section 3.3, I consider how the K’iche’ data at hand bear on the Syntactic Identity Condition (SIC) on ellipsis. I consider four alternative formulations of the SIC (Merchant 2013, Chung 2013, Rudin 2019, Ranero 2021), and argue that the K’iche’ data can only be accommodated under Ranero’s approach, which requires featural non-distinctness between the antecedent and elided material, but not full syntactic identity. Then, in section 3.4, I compare K’iche’ with the closely related language Kaqchikel, which does not allow AP-active

In section 4, I pursue further theoretical ramifications of this work. Section 4.1 discusses the purported ban on argument structure mismatches in ellipsis (see [Levin 1982](#), [Chung, Ladusaw, and McCloskey 1995](#), [Merchant 2013](#), a.o.). I show that argument structure alternations are a mixed bag, allowing mismatches in ellipsis precisely in those contexts that do not involve feature clashes. Section 4.2 points out a corollary of the present work for theories of features, namely that the syntax must contain privative features, but that the relationships between syntactic features cannot be fully expressed in privative terms. Furthermore, if the SIC prohibits feature clashes but does not require full featural identity between antecedents and ellipsis sites, then ellipsis can serve as a testing ground for hypotheses about the formal properties of syntactic feature systems more generally.

In this section, I provide some information about K'iche' and aspects of its grammar that are relevant to understanding the discussion that follows. K'iche', a Mayan language of the K'ichean branch, is spoken by around a million people in the highlands of Guatemala.³ The base word order is VOS (Kaufman 1990), as in (4a), but topicalized and focused DPs are frequently found in the preverbal position, in that order; see (4b), adapted from Can Pixabaj and England 2011: 19.

- K'iche is a morphologically ergative language, with ergativity manifested via agreement on the verb. As depicted in (5a), subjects of intransitive verbs in K'iche' trigger the same absolutive marking on the verb as objects of transitives, to the exclusion of subjects of transitive verbs, which trigger ergative marking. This alignment is different than the one observed in nominative-accusative languages,

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where transitive and intransitive subjects are grouped together to the exclusion of objects (5b).

(5) a. *Ergative-absolutive:*

ergative	absolutive
S – VTR	O – VTR
	S – VTR

b. *Nominative-accusative:*

nominative	accusative
S – VTR	O – VTR
S – VTR	

The contrast between the two alignment systems in (5) can be illustrated by comparing the K'iche' examples in (6a–b) with the Zulu examples in (7a–b). Like K'iche', Zulu allows verbal agreement with both subjects and objects. In K'iche', the object marker in the transitive (6a) corresponds to the subject marker in the intransitive clause (6b); in Zulu, the agreement marking treats subjects (transitive and intransitive) as a natural class, to the exclusion of objects (7a–b).

(6) a. K-at-u-sik'-ij.

NPST-ABS2SG-ERG3SG-call-TV
'S/he is calling you.'

b. K-at-b'in-ik.

NPST-ABS2SG-walk-IV
'You are walking.'

(7) a. u-mntwana u-cule i-ngoma

AUG-1.child 1s-sang 9.song
'The child sang a song.'

b. u-Mlungisi u-ya-gijima

AUG-1.Mlungisi 1s-YA-run
'Mlungisi is running.'

(adapted from Halpert 2012: 71)

K'iche' is also syntactically ergative, a property that places an important restriction on the types of mismatches that can be tested under ellipsis. Like other syntactically ergative languages, K'iche' obeys restrictions on the A'-extraction of transitive (ergative) subjects, a phenomenon that Aissen (2017) terms the *Ergative Extraction Constraint* (EEC). As shown in (8a), ergative subjects cannot be extracted from ordinary transitive clauses. By contrast, extraction of direct objects and intransitive subjects is fully grammatical (8b–c). To extract a transitive subject, K'iche' employs the so-called Agent Focus (AF) construction (9).

(8) a. *Are ri ixoq x-ø-u-b'aq ri ch'ajo'n.

EMPH DET woman PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-scrub DET clothes
intended: 'The woman scrubbed the clothes.'

- b. Are ri ch'ajo'n x-ø-u-b'aq ri ixoq.
 EMPH DET clothes PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-scrub DET woman
'The clothes, the woman scrubbed.'
- c. Are ri ala x-ø-ch'aw-ik.
 EMPH DET boy PST-ABS3SG-speak-IV
'The boy spoke.' (Can Pixabaj 2004: 58)
- (9) Are ri ixoq x-ø-b'aq-ow ri ch'ajo'n.
 EMPH DET woman PST-ABS3SG-scrub-AF DET clothes
'The woman scrubbed the clothes.'

AF has received extensive attention in the Mayanist literature and I do not discuss the details of its treatment here (see Coon, Mateo Pedro, and Preminger 2014, Aissen 2017, Ranero 2021, Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021, Royer and Coon 2025 for recent discussion and analyses). Notably, AF has sometimes been described as a *last resort* strategy because it appears only when required to circumvent the EEC. Accordingly, it is unavailable when the extracted element is a transitive object (10a) or an intransitive subject (10b), contexts in which extraction is independently permitted.

- (10) a. *Are ri ch'ajo'n x-ø-b'aq-ow ri ixoq.
 EMPH DET clothes PST-ABS3SG-scrub-AF DET woman
intended: 'The clothes, the woman scrubbed.'
- b. *Are ri ala x-ø-ch'aw-ow.
 EMPH DET boy PST-ABS3SG-speak-AF
intended: 'The boy spoke.'

Hence, the EEC has an important consequence for the present study: it prevents us from testing ellipsis configurations in which the AP appears in the ellipsis site. As I argue below, the K'iche' AP lacks an internal argument. Consequently, the only argument available for extraction from an AP clause is the external argument. While both AP and AF clauses allow the extraction of the external argument, the context in (11), where the antecedent contains an object, forces the use of AF rather than AP if the verb is to be spelled out; AP cannot be used in such contexts (for a further illustration of this point, see (42)). I take this to mean that the elliptical version of the same sentence also contains the AF.⁴ For this reason, the relevant ellipsis configurations

⁴As illustrated in (11), active-AF mismatches are also possible in K'iche' ellipsis, which is a pattern observed and discussed at length for Kaqchikel in Ranero 2021. While I do not study the K'iche' AF in any detail in this paper, it is possible that this pattern arises for the same reason as in Kaqchikel, namely because the AF encodes an absence of Voice altogether. In this way, AF-active mismatches could be accommodated under the non-distinctness approach to syntactic identity argued for in Ranero 2021 and in this paper. Moreover, the analysis of the K'iche' AP developed in this paper treats it as a regular active verb which lacks an internal argument. This means that a mismatch involving AP and AF should be allowed under ellipsis, since it does not involve any feature clashes. However, I have not been able to construct examples/contexts where AF is in the antecedent clause and AP is forced in the ellipsis site, or vice versa.

necessarily involve AP-active mismatches in only one direction: the AP appears in the antecedent, while the active transitive verb appears in the ellipsis site.

- (11) Ma-jun x-ø-u-b'aq ri ch'ajo'n, xaq xow Ixkeem
no-one PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-scrub DET clothes PRT just Ixkeem
(x-ø-b'aq-*ow* / x-ø-b'aq-*an*).
PST-ABS3SG-scrub-AF PST-ABS3SG-scrub-AP
'No one scrubbed the clothes, only Ixkeem (scrubbed (them)).'

As can be observed in examples (6) versus (8), K'iche' has two markers of tense/aspect (TA), namely *x-* and *k-*. I gloss these TA markers as past and non-past tense, respectively, while the Mayanist tradition understands them to mark completive and incompletive (viewpoint) aspect; see [Bešlin 2023b](#) for arguments that the markers signal tense in (Sololá) K'iche'. Nothing in the analysis hinges on whether these elements realize tense or aspect, since both of these projections are above the argument-introducing portion of the structure (VoiceP). However, since both of these TA markers are affixes (prefixes), and K'iche' does not have an equivalent of *do*-support, the entire verbal complex is elided in all cases of (finite) verbal ellipsis. Hence, all cases of finite verbal ellipses in K'iche' are at least TP ellipses and not vP/VoiceP ellipses.

Another set of affixes on verbal predicates are so-called *status suffixes* (SSs), which indicate verb class membership, based on transitivity, mood, and whether the verb is root or derived (Larsen 1988, Kaufman 1990, López Ixcoy 1997, Henderson 2012, a.o.). I show the SSs on simple intransitives, (12), so-called root transitives (13), and derived transitives (14), glossing them as TV (transitive) and IV (intransitive) throughout. Root transitives are those transitive verbs that are derived directly from CVC roots, while derived transitive have additional (morphosyntactic or phonological) material. As exemplified in (13)–(14) below, these two classes of transitives have different morphological patterns. Note that SSs appear only when the verb is in clause-final position, roughly corresponding to the minimal CP (see Henderson 2012 and Royer 2022 for a more careful qualification of this statement). As we will see immediately below and in section 3.2, the AP verb form carries the intransitive status suffix *-ik*.

- (12) K-in-b'in-ik.
NPST-ABS3SG-walk-IV
'I'm walking.'
- (13) X-ø-k-il-o.
PST-ABS3SG-ERG3PL-see-TV
'They saw it.'

- (14) X-ø-r-eta'm-*aj*.
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-know-TV
 'S/he learned it.'

Note also that the exact syntactic role and position of SSs is still contentious across Mayan (Coon 2016). K'iche' SSs have a distinct 'argument-counting' property; that is, the status suffix is *-ik* for one-argument verbs, regardless of whether those verbs are run-of-the-mill intransitives (15a), passives (15b), or AP (15c). Similarly, the derived transitive SS *-aj* appears equally on regular derived transitives (16a) as on causativized intransitives (16b). While this will not be crucial for my purposes, I assume that the SS projection sits higher than argument-introducing projections (as confirmed by its linear order). I also assume that SS has an agreement-type probe, which searches for DP arguments and has distinct exponence when it agrees with one versus two arguments (see Deal and Royer 2025 for an approach to ergative marking in Mayan which capitalizes on the same distinction).

- | | | | | | | |
|------|----|---|----|--|----|--|
| (15) | a. | tzaq- <i>ik</i>
fall-IV
'fall' | b. | xib'-ix- <i>ik</i>
hug-PASS-IV
'be hugged' | c. | tz'ib'-an- <i>ik</i>
write-AP-IV
'write' |
| (16) | a. | et- <i>aj</i>
measure-TV
'measure (sth.)' | b. | atin-is- <i>aj</i>
bathe-CAUS-TV
'bathe (sb.)' | | |

Finally, Mayan languages are traditionally said to have complex voice systems, including (some or all of) the active, one or more passives, one or more antipassives, agent focus, applicative, and instrumental voice (Dayley 1981, Mondloch 1981, Grinevald and Peake 2012, Coon 2016, Ranero 2021, a.o.). Here, I focus on the morphological expression of the active voice and the AP, which will be of relevance throughout the paper. As we have already seen in the examples above, the morphological expression of active voice is null.⁵ K'iche' has been argued to have up to three distinct antipassives: the absolutive antipassive (AP), the incorporative antipassive, and the focus antipassive (López Ixcoy 1997, Sis Iboy and López Ixcoy

⁵The SSs do not expone active voice; for example, passives based on derived transitives have the intransitive status suffix *-ik* clause-finally, as in (i).

- (i) K-ix-loq'-ox-*ik*.
 NPST-ABS2PL-love-PASS-IV
 'You are loved.'

(adapted from Mondloch 1981: 125)

While treating the SSs as separate from voice is quite standard, Aissen 2011 argues that the suffix on derived transitive verbs—(V)*j*—is an active voice suffix, and not a SS. Her argument is based on the fact that the suffix -(V)*j* is in complementary distribution with the passive and antipassive suffixes. While this is true, -(V)*j* is also in complementary distribution with the other status suffixes. Hence, I take the position that the active suffix is uniformly null and that the SS uniformly has phonological exponence.

2004, Can Pixabaj 2015). In this paper, I restrict my attention to the AP. Unlike the AP, the focus and incorporative antipassive have two syntactic arguments: an unspecified or generic object in the case of the incorporative antipassive (17) and an oblique object in the case of the focus antipassive (18). Moreover, their morphological exponent *-ow* on root bases mirrors that of AF, not AP (cf. the AF in (9)).

- (17) Utz k-in-paj-*ow* tɬam.
well NPST-ABS1SG-measure.out-AF liquor
'I liquor-measure well.'
(adapted from Mondloch 1981: 250)
- (18) Are le ak'al x-ø-loq'-*ow* lo k-eç le ak'.
EMPH DET child PST-ABS3SG-buy-AF DIR RN DET chicken
'The child bought the chickens.'
(adapted from Can Pixabaj 2015: 73)

On the other hand, the K'iche' AP has the suffix $-(V)n$, both with root bases (19a) and derived transitive bases (19b). In (Sololá) K'iche', the AP is therefore morphologically distinct from both the incorporative/focus antipassive and the AF construction.⁶ It is then likely that what has been termed a focus and incorporative “antipassive” is simply AF outside of its canonical context (*wh*-questions); see also Aissen 2011 for a discussion of this point.

- (19) a. Ri achi k-ø-mes-*on* ronojel q'ij waral.
DET man NPST-ABS3SG-sweep-AP every day here
'The man sweeps here every day.'
- b. Ri ak'al k-ø-tz'ib'-*an* ronojel q'ij.
DET boy NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP every day
'The boy writes every day.'

I discuss the morphological and syntactic characteristics of the AP in detail in section 3.2. I now turn to the main proposal of the paper.

3 Proposal

Based on data from feature mismatches in K'iche' ellipsis, I argue that the Syntactic Identity Condition (SIC) on ellipsis must be formulated in terms of featural non-distinctness (Ranero 2021, Ranero and Royer 2024), rather than featural identity (Merchant 2013, Chung 2013, Rudin 2019). Specifically, while clashing features are disallowed between the antecedent and the ellipsis site, the ellipsis site may contain features that are absent in the antecedent (or vice versa). Importantly, this condition is not restricted to portions of the clausal spine above the argument-introducing domain

⁶This difference is neutralized in some dialects of Qaqchikel, for example, where the suffix in question is uniformly *-(V)n* across all antipassives and the AF (Patal Majtzul et al. 2000).

(contra Chung 2013, Rudin 2019). To see this, I first offer evidence that K'iche' *xow*-constructions involve TP ellipsis (section 3.1), followed by evidence that the K'iche' AP is an active intransitive construction, which differs from the active transitive only in the fact that it lacks an internal argument (section 3.2). I then show how this state of things can be accounted for under a featural non-distinctness approach to the SIC, but not under other approaches which require identity (section 3.3). I close by comparing K'iche' with the closely related language Kaqchikel, in which surface-identical AP-active mismatches are disallowed (section 3.4).

3.1 *Xow-constructions involve ellipsis*

There is existing evidence that *xow*-constructions of the kind we have seen involve elided syntactic material, specifically sluicing (sluicing with non-*wh* remnants has been attested in other languages as well, see e.g., Lipták 2022 on Hungarian). The evidence comes from my investigation of exceptive-like *xow*-constructions in K'iche' (Bešlin 2023a). I show firstly that *xow*-phrases *can* be extended into a full clause (20) and that they can be modified by speaker-oriented adverbs (21).⁷ The latter fact supports the presence of hidden clausal structure on the mainstream assumption that speaker-oriented adverbs attach high in the clausal spine and cannot modify nominals (see Pérez-Jiménez and Moreno-Quibén 2012 and Soltan 2016 for the development of this diagnostic in the domain of exceptives).

- (20) Maj k-ø-u-tij-o, xow ri lej
 nothing NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3G-eat-TV just DET tortilla
 (k-ø-u-tij-o).
 NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3G-eat-TV
 'S/he doesn't eat anything, just tortillas (s/he eats).' (Bešlin 2023a: 10)

- (21) Konojel ri ak'al-ab' x-e-wa-ik, xow Ixkeem wane' no.
 all DET child-PL PST-ABS3SG-eat-IV just Ixkeem maybe NO
 'All the children ate, just Ixkeem maybe didn't.' (Bešlin 2023a: 12)

Furthermore, it has been observed that some exceptive constructions give rise to ambiguous interpretations in the context of sluicing (Potsdam and Polinsky 2019, Stockwell and Wong 2020; see also Merchant 2001: 22). While the interpretation in (22a) is expected for the sluice in (22), the availability of the reading in (22b) is a priori surprising, since the required antecedent (*John liked the movie*) is not present on the surface. This data can be accounted for if the exceptive itself supplies the antecedent thanks to its hidden clausal structure, as illustrated in (23).

⁷If the *xow*-phrase appears in a negative polarity context, as in (21), what we observe is sentential negation (Spanish *no* or K'iche' *ja'i'*). Predicate negation in K'iche' involves a circumfix *na...taj* which must attach to an overt element and is therefore not available when that element is elided.

- (22) Nobody liked the movie, except John, but I don't know why.
- a. ...but I don't know why <nobody liked the movie except John>.
 - b. ...but I don't know why <John liked the movie>.

- (23) Nobody liked the movie, except John [~~liked the movie~~].

Xow-constructions show the same kind of ambiguity in sluicing (24). The availability of the interpretation in (24b) shows that they too are underlyingly clausal.

- (24) Ma-jun utz k-ø-u-na' ri wa, xow ri nan Tax, pero
 no-one good NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-taste DET food only DET CLF Tasha but
 na wetam taj jacha'.
 NEG know IRR why
 'No one likes the food, just Doña Tasha, but I don't know why.'
- a. ...but I don't know why no one likes the food (just Doña Tasha).
 - b. ...but I don't know why Doña Tasha likes the food. (Bešlin 2023a: 11)

The next ellipsis diagnostic relies on the possibility of stranding syntactic material inside the ellipsis site. According to Merchant 2001, a language *L* allows (preposition) stranding under sluicing iff *L* allows (preposition) stranding under regular *wh*-movement. Hence, if K'iche' allows stranding and if the *xow*-construction involves clausal ellipsis, we should be able to strand and elide syntactic material within the clause. This prediction is borne out. To see this, consider the following: In K'iche', phrases headed by *ruk'* 'with' are used to introduce an accompaniment relation between the main clause subject and *ruk'*'s complement (25a). The *ruk'*-phrase can be questioned, in which case *ruk'* is either displaced along with its complement (25b) or it remains in situ (25c), just like its English equivalent *with*.⁸

- (25) a. Ri Lu' x-ø-xojow ruk' jun ixoq.
 DET Pedro PST-ABS3SG-dance RN one woman
 'Pedro danced with a woman.'
- b. Jachin ruk' x-ø-xojow ri Lu' ?
 who RN PST-ABS3SG-dance DET Pedro
 'With who did Pedro dance?'
- c. Jachin x-ø-xojow ri Lu' ruk' ?
 who PST-ABS3SG-dance DET Pedro RN
 'Who did Pedro dance with?'

⁸What we see in K'iche' (25c) is not strictly speaking preposition stranding since *ruk'* is a so-called relational noun. Relational nouns are a much more common way than prepositions of expressing spatio-temporal relations in Mayan languages. I leave the category issue aside, since what matters for our purposes is simply the fact that these elements can be stranded under movement.

Now, if a *ruk'* phrase is embedded inside an exceptive-like *xow*-construction, *ruk'* appears on the surface only optionally (26). I take this to mean that the *xow*-phrase is (standardly) focus-fronted prior to ellipsis, with *ruk'* either displaced along with it or stranded in situ and elided. If this is the correct analysis, we then have further evidence that *xow*-constructions involve ellipsis. Note that the optionality of *ruk'* in (26) cannot be due to something trivial like an existing instance of the same element in the main clause since overt *ruk'* is obligatory in both instances in cases of clausal coordination, for example (27).

- (26) Ri Lu' x-ø-xojow kuk' konojel le ixoq-ib', xow (ruk') ri
 DET Pedro PST-ABS3SG-dance RN every DET woman-PL just RN DET
 Tolor no.
 Dolores NO
 'Pedro danced with every girl, just not (with) Dolores.' (Bešlin 2023a: 12)

- (27) Ri Lu' x-ø-xojow *(ruk') jun ixoq y ri tat Max
 DET Pedro PST-ABS3SG-dance RN one woman and DET CLF Tomás
 x-ø-xojow *(ruk') konojel le ixoq-ib'.
 PST-ABS3SG-dance RN every DET woman-PL
 'Pedro danced with one woman & Don Tomás danced with every woman.'

Finally, K'iche' *xow*-phrases can include multiple exceptions that do not form a constituent unless they are in a full clause. In (28), *ri Lu'* 'Pedro' and *ruk' ri Tolor* 'with Dolores' form a constituent only together with the verb *xojowik* 'dance'. The surface form can be arrived at from the structure in (29), with both the subject and the *ruk'* phrase iteratively escaping the TP ellipsis site.

- (28) Konojel le achi-jab' x-e-xojow kuk' konojel le ixoq-ib', xow
 every DET man-PL PST-ABS3PL-dance RN every DET woman-PL just
 ri Lu' ruk' ri Tolor no.
 DET Pedro RN DET Dolores NO
 'Every boy danced with every girl, only Pedro didn't (dance) with Dolores.'
 (Bešlin 2023a: 11)

- (29) [_{FOCP} [_{DP} ri Lu] [_{FOCP} [_{DP} ruk' ri Tolor] ... [_{TP} [_{ri Lu}] xaxojow [_{ruk' ri Tolor}]]]]
-

Sentences like (28) look reminiscent of gapping, but we can show that the relevant deletion operation is, in fact, ellipsis. Gapping is traditionally understood to involve (vP or TP) coordination (Ross 1970, Neijt 1979, Wilder 1997 Merchant 2001, Johnson 2009, a.m.o.). It is furthermore observed that the portion of structure involving the gap cannot be fronted, possibly because the result would violate the Coordinate Structure Constraint (Ross 1967), see (30a–b). However, we can see that the fronting of

K'iche' *xow*-constructions is perfectly acceptable (31), demonstrating that they are not connected to the main predicate via coordination.⁹

- (30) a. John has eaten tortillas and Sue tamales.
 b. *Sue tamales, John has eaten tortillas and.
- (31) a. Xow ri lej, maj k-ø-u-tij-o.
 just DET tortilla nothing NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-eat-TV
 'Just tortillas, s/he doesn't eat anything (else).' (Bešlin 2023a: 6)
 b. Xow ri Lu' ruk' ri Tolor, ma-jun le achi-jab'
 just DET Pedro with DET Dolores no-one DET man-PL
 x-e-xojow kuk' ma-jun ixoq-ib'.
 PST-ABS3PL-dance with no-one woman-PL
 'Just Pedro with Dolores, no (other) man danced with any women.'

Moreover, elliptical constructions can be embedded, unlike structures that involve gapping (Ross 1970, Neijt 1979, Hankamer 1979, Williams 1997, Hartmann 2000, Johnson 2009, 2017; *pace* Jung 2022). This is illustrated for English by the contrast in (32a–b). K'iche' *xow*-constructions are routinely embedded, as in (33), suggesting again that they involve ellipsis and not gapping.

- (32) a. Some had bought cars and she claimed that others had done so too.
 b. *Some had bought cars and she claimed that others houses.
- (33) Maj k-ø-u-tij-o, xow ri lej
 nothing NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-eat-TV only DET tortilla
 x-ø-u-bij chwe <chi k-ø-u-tij-o>.
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-say to.me that NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-eat-TV
 'S/he doesn't eat anything, only tortillas s/he told me (s/he eats).'

Finally, K'iche' *xow*-constructions exhibit island repair properties to the same extent as typical sluicing constructions in K'iche' and in other languages (e.g., Merchant 2001). As seen in the often-cited English example in (34a), sluicing makes acceptable those sentences which seemingly violate island constraints and would therefore be unacceptable in the absence of ellipsis. K'iche' replicates this pattern both in typical sluicing environments (34b) and in *xow*-constructions (34c). Putting aside here the considerable literature on how best to deal with repair-by-ellipsis, and taking into consideration all the evidence we have seen for the presence of hidden clausal

⁹Note that the acceptability difference between the English and K'iche' sentences in (30)–(31) cannot be attributed to the presence/absence of an overt conjunction. In fact, the base gapping sentence in English is fine even without an overt conjunction (*John has eaten tortillas, Sue tamales.*), whereas the sentence with the fronted gap is still out (**Sue tamales, John has eaten tortillas.*)

structure with *xow*-phrases, this pattern confirms that the ellipsis phenomenon we are dealing with is comparable to classical sluicing.¹⁰

- (34) a. They want to hire someone who speaks a Balkan language, but I don't know which (Balkan language) ~~<they want to hire someone who speaks.>~~
- b. X-ø-ki-k'am loq ri ala k-ø-u-ch'o'b'
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3PL-bring PRT DET boy NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-know
 jun ch'ab'al mayab' pero man w-eta'm taj jachike.
 one language Maya but NEG ABS3SG-know IRR which
 'They brought the boy who speaks a Mayan language, but I don't know which.'
- c. X-ø-ki-k'am loq ri ala k-ø-u-ch'o'b'
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3PL-bring PRT DET boy NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-know
 konojel ri ch'ab'al mayab', xow ri K'iche' no.
 all DET language Maya just DET K'iche' no
 'They brought the boy who speaks all Mayan languages, just not K'iche'.'

In this section, I have shown evidence that the K'iche' *xow*-construction involves ellipsis. Since the elided verbs are finite, and finite verbs in K'iche' always involve prefixal tense morphology, we can be quite certain that the relevant kind of ellipsis is TP ellipsis. Crucially, in examples like (1) and (35)–(37), the ellipsis antecedent contains a verb in the AP form, yet the verb in the ellipsis site must be active transitive given the presence of the direct object.

- (35) Na k-ø-kem-on taj, xow we pas
 NEG NPST-ABS3SG-weave-AP IRR just DET sash
 <k-ø-u-kem-o>.
 NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-weave-TV
 'S/he doesn't (ever) weave, just traditional sashes.'
- (36) Na x-ø-loq'om-an ta pa k'ayb'al, xow ri k'aj
 NEG PST-ABS3SG-buy-AP IRR on market just DET flour
 <x-ø-u-loq'-o>.
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-buy-TV
 'S/he didn't buy at the market, just some flour.'

¹⁰ A reviewer wonders if (34c) might not be an instance of stripping. This possibility is not crucial for the present argument, since the null hypothesis is that the same considerations regarding syntactic identity will apply across different types of ellipsis. Nevertheless, two properties distinguish the construction from stripping. First, the *xow*-remnant can undergo fronting, whereas stripping does not permit fronting of the remnant. Second, the remnant may include adverbials such as *wane'* 'maybe', whereas stripping allows only a single phrasal constituent to survive ellipsis.

- (37) K-ø-su'-un le ixoq pa ri ja, xow ri uchi' ja no.
 NPST-ABS3SG-clean-AP DET woman on DET house just DET door house no
 'The woman is cleaning around the house, just not the door.'

This state of affairs constitutes a potential problem for theories which posit a Syntactic Identity Condition on ellipsis. To investigate this more closely, however, we need to understand in what way the AP differs from the active transitive form of the verb. In the following section, I show that the AP differs from the active transitive not in the flavor of Voice, but in that it is syntactically intransitive. Then, in section 3.3, I show how the K'iche' data can be accounted for on an approach to ellipsis which disallows feature clashes, but not on approaches which require syntactic identity.

3.2 *K'iche' AP is syntactically intransitive*

In this section, I argue that the K'iche' AP is syntactically intransitive and differs from the corresponding transitive verb only in this respect. To support this claim, I apply a range of syntactic diagnostics, several of which have also been used by [Burukina and Polinsky \(2025\)](#) to argue that the Kaqchikel AP lacks an internal argument.

First, notice that the AP only has absolutive marking (38a), a hallmark of intransitive constructions. Compare this to the transitive version of the verb in (38b), which tracks both ergative and absolutive.

- (38) a. Ixno'j na k-ø-tz'ib'-an taj.
 Ixno'j NEG NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP IRR
 'Ixno'j doesn't write.'
 b. Ixno'j na k-ø-u-tz'ib'-aj taj.
 Ixno'j NEG NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-write-TV IRR
 'Ixno'j doesn't write it.'

Moreover, overt objects—both definite and indefinite—are disallowed with AP (39a–b). On the other hand, topical arguments including objects are optionally overt with active transitive verbs (39c). In (39b), we also see that the AP patterns with other intransitives in the language in that it has the SS *-ik* in clause-final position; cf. (12).

- (39) a. Ixno'j na k-ø-tz'ib'-an taj (*we je'lik taq tzij).
 Ixno'j NEG NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP IRR DET pretty PL words
 'Ixno'j doesn't write (*poetry).'
 b. Ixno'j (*maj) k-ø-tz'ib'-an-ik.
 Ixno'j nothing NPST-ABS3SG-write-AP-IV
 'Ixno'j writes (*nothing).'

- c. Ixno'j na k-ø-u-tz'ib'-aj ta (we je'lik taq tzij).
 Ixno'j NEG NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-write-TV IRR DET pretty PL words
 'Ixno'j doesn't write it/poetry.'

Only syntactically represented arguments can host depictive and resultative modifiers; implicit (semantic) arguments cannot (Williams 1980, Mittwoch 1982, Levin and Rappaport Hovav 1995). Both kinds of arguments can be phonologically null. Hence, when a predicate has a null argument (as in the case of K'iche' AP), it is important to understand whether that argument is syntactically represented or not. For example, phonologically null objects in Italian can host depictives (40a), while their English counterparts cannot (40b). The depictive in the English sentence can only be hosted by the subject *John*; in Italian, it can also be hosted by a null plural object ('people'), as evidenced by the presence of plural marking on the depictive. Based on contrasts like (40a-b), Rizzi (1986) argues that Italian null objects are syntactically represented (as *pro*), while they are entirely absent in the syntax in English.

- (40) a. Di solito, Gianni fotografa sedut-i.
 in general Gianni photographs seated-PL
 'In general, Gianni photographs people seated.'
 b. In general, John photographs seated. (adapted from Rizzi 1986: 505)

In K'iche', depictives and resultatives are available with null objects of transitive verbs, but not with AP verb forms (41a-b). This is easily accommodated if AP is syntactically intransitive since there is nothing for the depictive/resultative to modify.

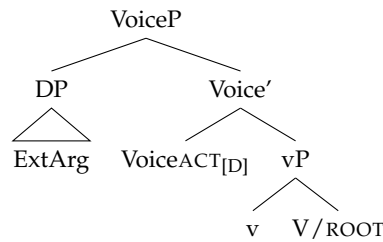
- (41) a. K'atinaq (ri lej) x-ø-u-b'an ri ak'al.
 burnt DET tortilla PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-make(TV) DET child
 'The child made the tortilla/it burnt.'
 b. *K'atinaq (ri lej) x-ø-b'an-on ri ak'al.
 burnt DET tortilla PST-ABS3SG-make-AP DET child
intended: 'The child made the tortilla/it burnt.'

Finally, we can show that patients/themes in K'iche' AP forms are not represented even as implicit arguments. Williams (2015) defends the claim that definite implicit arguments are explicitly specified in the grammar (and distinct from mere entailments), whereas indefinite implicit arguments are not. In K'iche', definite implicit objects are allowed if the verb has transitive morphology, but not if it is AP. The sentence in (42), which establishes a context in which particular güipiles are under discussion, can be felicitously continued with a sentence containing a transitive verb (42a), but not an AP verb (42b). This shows that the understood object in AP sentences can only be indefinite and suggests that AP lacks a grammatical representation of the object altogether.

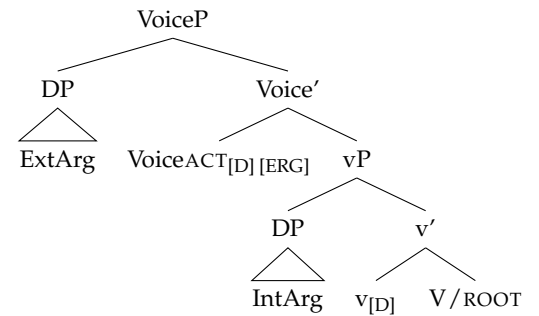
- (42) **Context:** X-e-ki-tzer ri kipo't konojel ri ixoq-ib'.
 PST-ABS3PL-ERG3PL-tear DET güipiles all DET woman-PL
 'All the women tore their güipiles.'
- a. Ri nim-a'q taq ixoq-ib' x-e-ki-tis-o.
 DET big-PL PL woman-PL PST-ABS3PL-ERG3PL-repair-TV
 'The old women repaired them.'
- b. # Ri nim-a'q taq ixoq-ib' x-e-tisom-an-ik.
 DET big-PL PL woman-PL PST-ABS3PL-repair-AP-IV
intended: 'The old women repaired them.'
available: 'The old women did some repairing.'

The structure I propose for the K'iche' AP is given in (43a); cf. the active transitive in (43b). The two structures are relatively similar, except for the presence of [D] and [ERG] features in the active transitive, which are responsible for selecting the internal argument and licensing ergative case on the external argument, respectively (that the locus of ergative case in languages like K'iche' is *v*/Voice is argued for extensively in Coon, Mateo Pedro, and Preminger 2014; absolutive is licensed by Infl/T).¹¹ As I will detail in the following section, this structure allows us to explain why the AP/transitive mismatch is possible under Ranero's approach to the SIC (but not others): There is no feature clash; the ellipsis site in the AP/transitive mismatch sentences simply has extra features—[D] on *v* and [ERG] on Voice—which are absent in the antecedent.¹²

(43) a. *K'iche'* AP



b. *K'iche'* active transitive



¹¹I assume that the [D] feature responsible for the presence of the internal argument is on (the categorizer) *v*, since the same root in a nominal environment may not introduce an argument. It is not crucial for my purposes whether the internal argument is *introduced* as the specifier of *v* or elsewhere, for example, as the complement of V/the root (though this would raise questions regarding the locality of selection, see e.g., Hornstein 2024). If *v* is responsible for introducing the internal argument, then the correlation between the presence of the internal argument and the presence of [ERG] can be straightforwardly implemented through selection. Specifically, Voice with an [ERG] feature selects for *v* with a [D] feature only.

¹²Recall that AP and transitive verbs also have distinct status suffixes (SSs). I do not include a representation of the SSs in (43) so as to keep these representations comparable to the minimal (VoiceP) representations of the Kaqchikel AP in the following section. However, recall that I argued SSs have an agreement-type probe, which searches for DP arguments and has distinct exponence when it agrees with ones versus two arguments. A mismatch between the different SSs does not cause a feature clash since the transitive SS differs from the AP SS only in that it contains an extra set of number/person features.

As shown in (43), I am arguing that the Voice_{ACT} projection is shared between the active transitive and the AP. As in uncontroversially active sentences, the Voice projection in the AP then has null exponence. This view differs from the mainstream, with Mondloch, for example, stating that the K'iche' "absolutive voice marker is the verbal suffix *-(V)n*" (Mondloch 1981: 184). Instead, I argue that *-(V)n* is the exponent of intransitive *v* (*v* without a [D] feature), as already suggested for the Kaqchikel cognate in Burukina and Polinsky 2025. Two pieces of evidence support this claim for K'iche'. First, many regular intransitive verbs look like they are derived from typical monosyllabic roots followed by the suffix *-(V)n*, as shown in (44).¹³

- | | | | | | | |
|------|----|------------|----|-------------|----|------------|
| (44) | a. | b'ix-on-ik | c. | at-in-ik | e. | uxl-an-ik |
| | | sing-VN-IV | | bathe-VN-IV | | rest-VN-IV |
| | | 'sing' | | 'bathe' | | 'rest' |
| | b. | xik'-an-ik | d. | mux-an-ik | f. | etz'-an-ik |
| | | jump-VN-IV | | swim-VN-IV | | play-VN-IV |
| | | 'jump' | | 'swim' | | 'play' |

Moreover, intransitive verbs in K'iche' usually have transitive counterparts, derived in one of two ways. The first way is where (descriptively speaking) the transitive SS *-(V)j* replaces *-(V)n* and attaches directly to the root (45); cf. (44a). This lends some credence to the idea that (i) *-(V)n* is a morpheme distinct from the root even in plain intransitives and (ii) *-Vn* is associated with intransitivity, plausibly as an exponent of *v* which lacks a [D] feature. I discuss the second way of deriving transitive verbs—namely causativization—in section 3.4, where I provide a comparison of K'iche' APs and their counterparts in Kaqchikel.

- (45) K-ø-u-b'ix-aj b'ixamaq' rech Paxil Kayala' ri ali.
 NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-sing-TV anthem RN Guatemala DET girl
 'The girl is singing the national anthem of Guatemala.' (ALMG 2010: 21)

In this section, I have provided extensive argumentation for the claim that the K'iche' AP is intransitive. Specifically, I argued that its structure is parallel to that of

¹³My consultants show no systematic syntactic distinction between unaccusative and unergative verbs. In some closely related Mayan languages like Santiago Tz'utujil and Kaqchikel, the distinction is potentially detectable through agreement patterns. In these languages, arguments of unaccusatives pattern with other internal arguments in the languages under discussion, in that 3PL animates trigger agreement on the verb only optionally, while external arguments do so obligatorily (Lyskawa and Ranero 2022, Burukina and Polinsky 2025). As discussed in Lyskawa and Ranero 2022, this pattern could be the result of animacy restrictions, rather than unaccusativity itself: animate arguments control agreement obligatorily, and while verbs like *fall* can combine with inanimates, verbs like *walk* cannot (see also England 2011). A similar pattern has been reported in Fried, Lyskawa, and Ranero 2021 for at least one speaker on K'iche'. However, my consultants mark agreement obligatorily even with 3PL inanimate arguments of intransitive verbs, as seen in (i).

- (i) Keb' wa'is x-e'/*ø-tzaq pa le ulew.
 two pots PST-ABS3PL/*ø-fall on DET floor
 'Two pots fell on the floor.'

active transitive verbs, except for the lack of [D] on *v* and [ERG] on Voice, recall (43). Next, I discuss the different formulations of the SIC on ellipsis and the nature of the SIC that can accommodate the facts at hand.

3.3 Accounting for the K'iche' data

Before considering the various proposals concerning the SIC on ellipsis in detail, it is useful to briefly discuss English examples such as (46), commonly referred to as *sprouting*. At first glance, these examples resemble the K'iche' mismatches investigated in this paper: the antecedent contains an implicit object, whereas the ellipsis site contains an overt one. Such examples have played an important role in the ellipsis literature, serving as evidence against a SIC on ellipsis in Merchant (2001) and against identity requirements on the tails of movement chains in Rudin (2019).

- (46) Sally ate, but I don't know what <Sally ate what>. (Merchant 2001: 19)

There are a few things to say here. First, if we take it for granted that the antecedent verb in (46) lacks a syntactic internal argument (while the verb in the ellipsis site clearly has one), then the difference between the two is not just in the presence of a tail of a movement chain in the ellipsis site, but also in the selectional features of the two verbs, a fact that is ignored in Rudin 2019. Second, examples such as (46) are quite extraordinary in English; this kind of alternation is not productive and there is no consensus on how exactly the verbs in the antecedent and the ellipsis site differ from each other syntactically, if at all. Hence, the K'iche' data is useful because the transitive/AP alternation is productive and has a number of visible correlations in addition to the presence/absence of the internal argument (as discussed in section 3.2).

Second, I adopt Rudin's proposal that the SIC ignores the tails of movement chains. A particularly clear illustration of why such a provision is necessary comes from the English examples in (47) and (48), adapted from Chung (2006). The ellipsis site is identical across these examples; the relevant differences concern the antecedent and the sluice remnant. First, (47) and (48) differ in whether the antecedent contains a *to*-phrase. Second, the (a) and (b) examples differ in whether the preposition *to* is pied-piped with the remnant DP or remains inside the ellipsis site.

- (47) a. We're donating our car to some organization, but it's unclear *to which organization* <we're donating our car to which organization>.
 b. We're donating our car to some organization, but it's unclear *which organization* <we're donating our car to which organization>.
- (48) a. We're donating our car, but it's unclear *to which organization* <we're donating our car to which organization>.

- b. * We're donating our car, but it's unclear *which organization*
~~<we're donating our car to which organization>~~.

The crucial observation is that a preposition may not be stranded inside the ellipsis site if there is no corresponding preposition in the antecedent (48b). By contrast, the sentence becomes acceptable when the preposition is pied-piped together with the sluice remnant (48a), even though the pied-piping derivation arguably leaves a copy of *to* within the ellipsis site. This pattern is an instance of *Chung's Generalization*, according to which P-stranding is impossible under sprouting.

The contrast between (48a) and (48b) indicates that the SIC disregards the tails of movement chains.¹⁴ In (48a), the copy of *to* inside the ellipsis site does not have to match anything in the antecedent because it forms part of a movement tail. In (48b), by contrast, *to* remains in situ within the ellipsis site and therefore gives rise to a mismatch with the antecedent. The implication for the K'iche' AP/transitive alternation is that the copy of the extracted object DP in the transitive ellipsis site is not itself part of the mismatch that requires an explanation.¹⁵

Even once these considerations are taken into account, the K'iche' data highlight a question that English examples such as (46) may obscure: We are still in need of an explanation for how an active transitive and AP verb can mismatch in features under ellipsis. In order to answer that question, let us examine in more detail the various formulations of the SIC on ellipsis, laid out in (49).

- (49) a. **Merchant 2013**: The heads in the verbal spine of the elided constituent must be syntactically identical to the corresponding heads in the antecedent.¹⁶
- b. **Chung 2013**: A predicate in the ellipsis site must have an argument structure identical to the argument structure of the corresponding predicate in the antecedent clause. If the interrogative phrase of the sluice is a DP, it must be Case-licensed by a head in the ellipsis site identical to a corresponding head in the antecedent clause.
- c. **Rudin 2019**: The heads in the eventive core (=highest vP that is associated with an event introducing predicate) of the elided constituent

¹⁴I do not discuss in detail the issue of *why* the SIC seems to ignore tails of movement chains. [Ranero \(2021\)](#) suggests that this is because the SIC imposes an identity between the antecedent and material *properly contained* within the ellipsis site, see (49d). Since the sluice remnant in the target clause is the highest link of a movement chain which is not properly contained within the ellipsis site, it is ignored for the purposes of the SIC. Note that this view is in potential tension with findings from [Gribanova's](#) work, which finds that a verb remnant in verb-stranding VP-ellipsis in languages like Russian cannot mismatch in some cases with the verb in the antecedent ([Gribanova 2017](#); cf. [Gribanova 2013](#)). A full analysis of the factors that may be leading to these differences is beyond the scope of this paper; see [Saab 2022](#) for a recent discussion of the relevant facts.

¹⁵I assume here the Copy-theory of movement ([Chomsky 1995](#)), but nothing hinges on this choice. If movement leaves behind traces, then the SIC must ignore them for purposes of calculating identity.

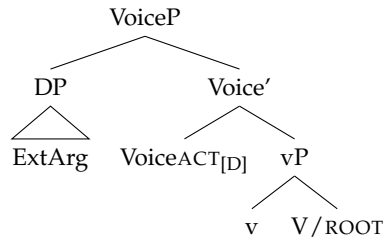
¹⁶Note that [Merchant](#) never actually spells out the identity condition explicitly in this work; the above is an interpretation of his proposal found in [Chung 2013](#).

must be syntactically identical to the corresponding heads in the antecedent.

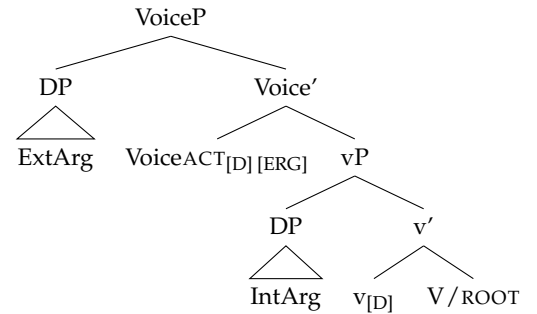
- d. **Ranero 2021**: The antecedent and material properly contained in the ellipsis site must be featurally non-distinct; roots must match one-to-one.

To facilitate the discussion of these proposals in relation to the K'iche' mismatches, I repeat the structure of the K'iche' AP and active transitive verb in (50). We can immediately reject **Merchant's** proposal, since the heads in the verbal spine of active transitive and AP verbs in K'iche' are clearly not identical: The active transitive *v* selects for a DP internal argument (has a selectional [D] feature), and the AP *v* does not. Moreover, the active transitive Voice head licenses ergative case on the external argument (has an [ERG] feature), and the AP Voice head does not. Further representative examples of why complete syntactic identity cannot be a prerequisite for ellipsis can be found in **Potsdam 2007**, **Chung 2013**, **Rudin 2019** and **Ranero 2021**.

(50) a. *K'iche'* AP



b. *K'iche'* active transitive



Next, I address **Chung's** and **Rudin's** proposals in tandem, given that they are unable to accommodate the K'iche' data for similar reasons. Both proposals privilege the argument-introducing portion of the verbal spine, in essence arguing that this part of the structure must be identical in the antecedent and the ellipsis site (while higher portions of the structure may mismatch). **Chung's** proposal directly references the argument structure domain, while **Rudin's** includes it since the highest vP associated with an event-introducing predicate properly contains all of the argument-introducing heads. However, as we have seen, the K'iche' data challenge the conclusion that syntactic identity in the argument structure domain is a prerequisite for ellipsis since the transitive and AP verb differ in whether they introduce an internal argument or not, as well as in whether ergative case is assigned or not. I refer the reader to **Rudin 2019** for further empirical arguments against the proposal in **Chung 2013** and to **Saab 2014** and **Ranero 2021** for data that clearly contradicts the formulation of the SIC as in **Rudin 2019**.

Finally, **Ranero (2021)** argues that the SIC is formulated in terms of "featural non-distinctness", meaning that it allows feature mismatches, but not feature clashes.

In other words, the antecedent may contain features absent in the ellipsis site (or vice versa) so long as the same head in the antecedent and ellipsis site does not contain clashing features. For example, [Ranero](#) shows that certain voice mismatches are allowed under sluicing in the Mayan language Kaqchikel if they involve so-called Agent Focus (AF) voice in either the antecedent (51) or the ellipsis site (52). As discussed in section 2, AF is a construction found in many Mayan languages and used obligatorily when the transitive subject undergoes A'-extraction (in *wh*-questions or focus constructions, for example); see [Aissen 2017](#) for an overview. Agent focus can mismatch with both the active and the passive, as illustrated in (51)–(52).¹⁷ On the other hand, AP-active mismatches are disallowed in Kaqchikel sluicing, (53).¹⁸ These results are replicated for another Mayan language, Chuj, in [Ranero and Royer 2024](#).

- (51) A: Xa xe ri ma Juan x-ø-loq'-o kotch'i'j.
 EMPH only DET CLF Juan PST-ABS3SG-buy-AF flower
 'Only Juan bought flowers.'
- B: Kan qitzij? Ta-b'ij pe chwe achike kotz'i'j
 PRT truth IMP-say PRT to.me what flower
 <x-ø-u-löq'>!
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-buy.ACT
 'Really? Tell me which flowers!'
- (52) A: Ri aq x-ø-kam-is-äx ruma jun ixöq.
 DET pig PST-ABS3SG-die-CAUS-PASS RN a woman.
 'The pig was killed by a woman.'
- B: Kan qitzij? Achike ixöq <x-ø-kam-sa-n ri aq>?
 PRT truth which woman PST-ABS3SG-die-CAUS-AF DET pig
 'Really? Which woman (killed the pig)?'
- (53) *Xta Juana n-ø-k'ay-in pa k'ayib'al wkami. Ta-wla achike
 CLF Juana NPST-ABS3SG-sell-AP on market now IMP-guess what
 <n-ø-k'ay-ij>!
 NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-buy-ACT.TV
 intended: 'Juana is selling (something) at the market now. Guess what!'

[Ranero \(2021\)](#) argues that mismatches involving AF are possible in Kaqchikel because its AF construction lacks a Voice projection altogether. By contrast, he analyzes active and AP verbs in Kaqchikel as bearing distinct values of Voice—namely ACTIVE and ANTIPASSIVE—with the result that AP-active mismatches

¹⁷In (52), the verb in the ellipsis site must be in the agent focus form and not passive with P-stranding. P-stranding is impossible in Kaqchikel (unlike in K'iche'), see the discussion in [Ranero 2021](#): 119–21.

¹⁸Active/passive and passive/active mismatches cannot be tested in Kaqchikel or K'iche' for independent reasons, see [Ranero 2021](#): section 2.5.

under ellipsis involve a feature clash and are therefore ruled out. Although I adopt a revised analysis of the Kaqchikel AP in section 3.4, based on recent evidence from [Burukina and Polinsky 2025](#), the crucial point remains unchanged: the AP and active transitive constructions in Kaqchikel differ in their feature composition in a way that yields a feature clash under ellipsis. I therefore set aside the details of the Kaqchikel analysis here and refer the reader to [Ranero 2021](#) for the arguments underlying these conclusions. More generally, [Ranero](#) shows that a non-distinctness-based formulation of the SIC correctly predicts not only the Kaqchikel facts, but also a broader range of documented mismatch and non-mismatch patterns under ellipsis (see especially chapters 3 and 4).

The featural non-distinctness approach to the SIC straightforwardly accounts for the K'iche' data examined in this paper. The only difference between the active transitive and the AP verb is that the AP lacks the [D] and [ERG] features responsible for selecting the internal argument and licensing the external argument of the transitive, respectively. Since the lack of these features does not constitute a feature-clash, it is allowed under ellipsis. In the next section, I undertake a comparison of the K'iche' AP and its counterpart in the closely related language Kaqchikel. As we have seen, AP-active mismatches are disallowed in Kaqchikel. I show independent evidence that the AP in the two languages has a distinct underlying structure. In Kaqchikel, I follow [Burukina and Polinsky's \(2025\)](#) analysis of Kaqchikel APs and argue that it is necessary to posit distinct featural specifications for *v* on active transitive verbs and APs in order to account for their selectional restrictions. This distinct featural specification on *v* leads to a feature clash under ellipsis, accounting for why AP-active mismatches are disallowed in Kaqchikel.

3.4 AP: A comparison with Kaqchikel

As we have seen, AP-active mismatches are impossible in Kaqchikel sluicing (54). Compare this to the very similar (yet acceptable) K'iche' sentence in (55). In this section I lay out evidence (beyond ellipsis) that the AP has a different structure in the two languages, despite surface similarities.

- (54) * Xta Juana n-ø-k'ay-in pa k'ayib'al wkami. Ta-wla achike
 CLF Juan NPST-ABS3SG-sell-AP on market now IMP-guess what
 <n-ø-ø-k'ay-ij>!
 PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-buy-ACT
intended: 'Juana is selling (something) at the market now. Guess what!'
- (55) Ri nan Juana k-ø-k'ay-in pa k'ayib'al. Ch-a-ch'ak-a'
 DET CLF Juana NPST-ABS3SG-sell-AP on market IMP-ABS2SG-guess-IMP
 jas uwach ri jastaq <k-ø-u-k'ay-ij>!
 what kind DET thing NPST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-sell-TV

‘Doña Juana sells at the market. Guess what kind of thing <she sells>!’

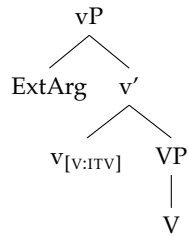
Ranero (2021) argues that the structure of AP in Kaqchikel is as in (56a) and that the reason mismatches with the active are disallowed is because the Voice head has an AP feature, whereas in the active voice it is specified for active (56b), which leads to a feature clash in ellipsis contexts.¹⁹ Ranero does not specify the position of the sole argument in the AP construction.

(56) *Ranero’s analysis of the Kaqchikel AP and active transitive:*

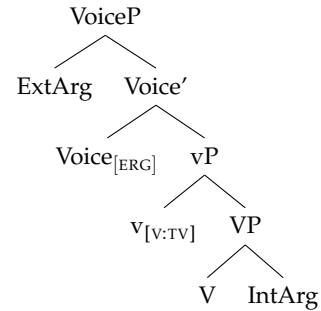
- a. [... Voice_[AP] [... v_{trans} [... V]]]
- b. [... Voice_{[ACT][ERG]} [... v_{trans} [... V]]]

In more recent work, Burukina and Polinsky (2025) have taken the distinction between the active transitive and the AP in Kaqchikel to be in transitivity. Like the K’iche’ AP discussed in this paper, the Kaqchikel AP is claimed to lack an internal argument. Beyond this, however, Burukina and Polinsky argue that transitive and intransitive external arguments are introduced in different structural positions. Specifically, they propose that the external arguments of intransitive verbs—including AP verbs—are introduced by *v*, whereas the external arguments of transitive verbs are introduced by Voice (57). Their proposal thus adopts a “small” analysis of intransitives, under which intransitive verbs do not project Voice.

(57) a. *Kaqchikel AP*



b. *Kaqchikel active transitive*



Burukina and Polinsky use the shorthand ITV for intransitive verbs and TV for transitive verbs, which may initially suggest that they assume these to be heads with potentially clashing features. This would account for the impossibility of AP-active mismatches in Kaqchikel ellipsis. However, they explain that these are shorthand labels for *v* with and without a nominal selectional feature. For them, “intransitive” *v*

¹⁹Ranero also posits an [EPP] feature on Voice_{ACT}, which attracts the absolutive argument in so-called high-Absolutive languages like Kaqchikel (and K’iche’), and drives the syntactic ergativity effects we observe in these languages. This detail is not crucial for my analysis here, so I omit it in the schematic representations and in the discussion that follows. If this feature is present in transitive constructions and absent in intransitive ones, the mismatch would be allowed under ellipsis in the same way as the presence/absence of an [ERG] or [D] feature. However, it is unclear to me how one would tell if the [EPP] feature on Voice is present or absent on intransitive verbs of any kind, since syntactic ergativity is not manifested in these constructions.

is simply *v* that selects for a nominal argument (while the arguments of transitive verbs are introduced by *V* and Voice). In principle, then, there is no feature clash between the AP and active transitive verb on this account of their structure (see [Burukina and Polinsky 2025](#): Table 3).

I return to the question of “small” intransitives immediately below, arguing that there is evidence the K’iche’ AP differs in this from the Kaqchikel AP (and from other, inherent intransitives in both languages). First, however, it is worth noting that, under standard assumptions about selection, Kaqchikel must distinguish between [*v*:TV] and [*v*:ITV]: (i) only [*v*:TV] can be selected by Voice, and (ii) only [*v*:TV] can select for a VP with an internal argument, as in (57). [Burukina and Polinsky](#) gesture toward a semantic explanation of (i), writing that [*v*:TV] “introduces a new thematic relation (Agent), but that head is defective in that it does not project a syntactic argument. This leaves the transitive *v*P unsaturated and the EA relation must be taken care of for the derivation to be interpretable at LF. Under our proposal, it is Voice that does the job.” ([Burukina and Polinsky 2025](#):20). However, as I show below on the basis of causativization, K’iche’ AP is clearly a Voice phenomenon, in the sense that the intransitive AP verb nevertheless projects Voice. Since Voice is therefore not restricted to transitive verbs in K’iche’, there is no reason to regard such a restriction as a consequence of general semantic principles. Consequently, if the Kaqchikel AP is indeed a small structure lacking Voice, the inability of Voice to combine with it must be encoded in the syntax.

Moreover, we are left with (ii): why does *v*ITV select only VPs with internal arguments, while *v*ITV selects only VPs without them? This too appears to require c-selectional restrictions. In other words, *v*TV and *v*ITV must constitute distinct syntactic “flavors” of *v* in Kaqchikel, allowing them to (i) uniquely select different kinds of phrases and (ii) be uniquely selected by Voice or not, assuming the relevant features on *v* are able to percolate to the *v*P level. If Kaqchikel indeed has two distinct *v* heads with distinct featural content (say, TV and ITV), this also explains the impossibility of AP-active mismatches under ellipsis on a featural non-distinctness approach to the SIC, cf. (57a)/(57b).

Let me now return to the structural differences between Kaqchikel and K’iche’ APs by discussing patterns of causativization in the two languages. As illustrated with the pairs of verbs in (58)-(61), causativization is a productive way of transitivizing intransitive verbs in K’iche’ (see [López Ixcoy 1997](#), [Gluckman 2015](#), [Marroquin Pelíz and Mateo Pedro 2021](#) for more examples). While causativization of intransitives is possible and productive in K’iche’, active transitives and passives cannot be causativized (62). Importantly, AP cannot be causativized either (63). Therefore, with respect to causativization, K’iche’ AP does not pattern with inherently intransitive verbs in the language, but rather with active transitives and passives, verb forms that are the prime candidates to contain Voice.

- | | | | |
|---------|---|----|--|
| (58) a. | kam-ik
die-IV
'die' | b. | kam-sa-j
die-CAUS-TV
'kill' |
| (59) a. | atin-ik
wash-IV
'wash (self)' | b. | atin-isa-j
wash-CAUS-TV
'wash (sb.)' |
| (60) a. | b'in-ik
walk-IV
'walk' | b. | b'in-isa-j
walk-CAUS-TV
'walk (sb.), handle' |
| (61) a. | kix-ik
shame-IV
'be ashamed' | b. | kix-sa-j
shame-CAUS-TV
'shame' |
| (62) a. | * loq'-sa-j
buy-CAUS-TV
'make buy (sth.)' | b. | * tz'ib'-ax-sa-j
write-PASS-CAUS-TV
'make be written (by sb.)' |
| (63) a. | * X-e-qa-k'ay-in-sa-j /
PST-ABS3PL-ERG1PL-sell-AP-CAUS-TV
x-e-qa-loq'-on-sa-j pa k'ayb'al ronojel q'ij.
PST-ABS3PL-ERG1PL-buy-AP-CAUS-TV in market every day
'We made them sell/buy at the market every day.' | | |
| b. | * X-e-qa-tz'ib'-an-sa-j pa qa-tzij.
PST-ABS3PL-ERG1PL-write-AP-CAUS-TV in A1PL-language
'We made them write in our language.' | | |

Following [Burukina and Polinsky 2025](#), I take the contrasts above to suggest that inherent intransitives in K'iche' are small constructions (vPs) as in Kaqchikel, and that causativization in these languages is a vP phenomenon. That is, causativization in K'iche' and Kaqchikel involves vP iteration: adding a vCAUS on top of another vP. Furthermore, while vP recursion is allowed, a vP cannot be merged on top of a VoiceP (hence, the restriction on causatives of transitives and passives). Moreover, the fact that K'iche' AP cannot be causativized (63) suggests that it too involves the projection of Voice. If AP were a small vP construction, there should in principle be no issue with its causativization. If my analysis is on the right track and (i) vCAUS is a vP phenomenon while (ii) AP is a Voice phenomenon in K'iche', we then expect K'iche' causatives to be able to antipassivize. This is in fact what we observe (64).

- (64) **Context:** Talking about duties of family members in child-rearing...

Le' nan k-e'-atin-is-an, le' ati't
 DET mother NPST-ABS3PL-wash-CAUS-AP DET grandma
 k-e-war-tis-an.
 NPST-ABS3PL-sleep-CAUS-AP
 'Mothers bathe, grandmothers put to sleep.'

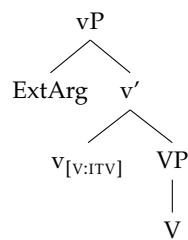
If both causativization and antipassivization in Kaqchikel are vP phenomena (Burukina and Polinsky 2025), we potentially expect to see both causativized antipassives and antipassivized causatives in the language. While causativization is generally not as productive in Kaqchikel as it is in K'iche', examples of both suffix orders can be found in published work, compare (65) from Burukina and Polinsky 2025: fn. 14 and (66) from García Matzar and Rodríguez Guaján 1997: 437.

- (65) La yawa' x-ø-u-chul-un-isa-j ri kik'.
 DET patient PST-ABS3SG-ERG3SG-urinate-AP-CAUS-TV DET blood
 'The patient urinated over some blood.'

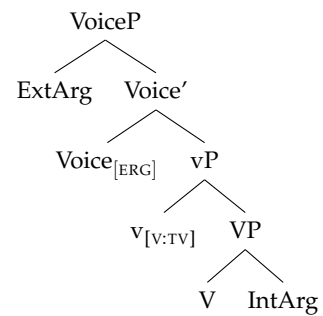
- (66) X-e-saqar-isa-n chi Iximche' ri ajq'ij-a'.
 PST-B3PL-white-CAUS-AP in Iximche' DET priest-PL
 'The Mayan priests woke up in Iximche'.
lit. 'The Mayan priests made white in Iximche'.'

We therefore have independent evidence from causativization patterns that K'iche' APs project Voice, while their Kaqchikel counterparts do not. As we have seen in (57), repeated here in (67), the Kaqchikel AP and active transitive verb differ (at least) in that they have different flavors of v (transitive versus intransitive). This assumption was needed to account for their selectional restrictions. In K'iche', on the other hand, no such provision was necessary. As seen in (43), repeated here in (68), the K'iche' AP and active transitive differ only in that the AP lacks the [D] and [ERG] features present on the active transitive verb.

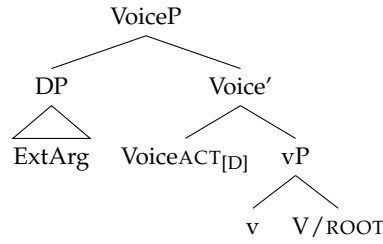
- (67) a. *Kaqchikel AP*



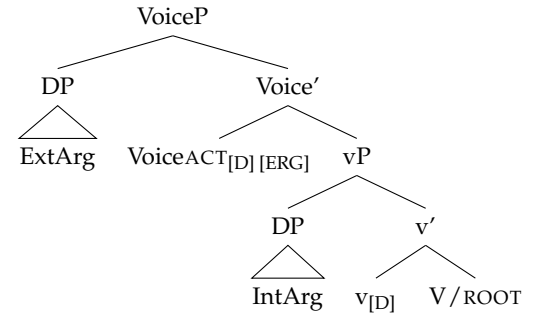
- b. *Kaqchikel active transitive*



(68) a. *K'iche'* AP



b. *K'iche'* active transitive



Before I close this section, I would like to point out one more, perhaps less obvious conclusion of the work presented in this paper. Namely, if it is correct that *K'iche'* AP is essentially an active intransitive verb and that *Kaqchikel* AP has a small structure (while the passive voice may involve the manipulation of Voice features, see e.g., [Ranero 2021](#)), then there is no unified notion of “voice” in grammar (see [Wood and Tyler 2025](#) for related discussion). In other words, what we call *active*, *passive* and *antipassive* voice may involve distinct structures in different (even closely related) languages. If the surface expression of these structures is similar enough, it is likely that they have been subsumed under the same general labels. I also refer the reader to [Heaton’s 2017](#) typological study of antipassives, where she makes this point for the active-antipassive alternation specifically. She shows that what is referred to as *antipassive* in the linguistics literature and in grammars is a cluster of traits, some of which may be absent in antipassives in individual languages, and some of which may be present in constructions that are not (referred to as) antipassive. This point is also pertinent if we look at voice systems of Austronesian languages, where the label “voice” disguises phenomena that are very distinct in nature than the argument-altering voices in more familiar languages (see [Erlewine, Levin, and Urk 2017](#) for an overview). For example, [Lennox, Chen, and Potsdam’s \(in press\)](#) analysis of voice-mismatches under ellipsis in Phillipine-type voice systems relies on the idea that “voice” in these languages is encoded as an Agree relation between a DP and a position in the high left periphery. That is, the relevant feature is outside the ellipsis site, even in sluicing (a similar analysis can also be found in [Ranero 2021](#): section 5.2.1). This is very different than the notion of voice we have seen in this paper and there seems to be little grounds for their theoretical unification.

4 Extensions

In this section, I discuss the implications of the work presented in this paper beyond the SIC. First, in section 4.1, I offer some comments on the purported unavailability of argument structure mismatches in ellipsis contexts. I argue that argument structure alternations can arise due to distinct underlying structures cross-linguistically; the

mismatches are only unavailable when they involve feature-clashes. Then, in section 4.2, I offer some thoughts on the implications of the present work regarding theories of syntactic features. I show that the featural non-distinctness approach to the SIC, if true, argues quite forcefully for the inclusion of both privative and non-privative features in the syntax. Moreover, ellipsis may then serve as a detector of privative features, hence allow us to test hypotheses about the formal properties of syntactic feature systems.

4.1 *Argument structure alternations*

What we observed with the K'iche' active transitive-AP mismatch examples is essentially an argument structure alternation (transitive-intransitive). Argument structure alternations have been argued to be impossible under ellipsis (Levin 1982, Chung, Ladusaw, and McCloskey 1995, Merchant 2001, 2013, Chung 2013, Rudin 2019). For example, Merchant (2013) proposes to subsume the ban on active-passive mismatches in English clausal ellipsis (69) to a more general prohibition on argument structure mismatches in predicate ellipsis (70).

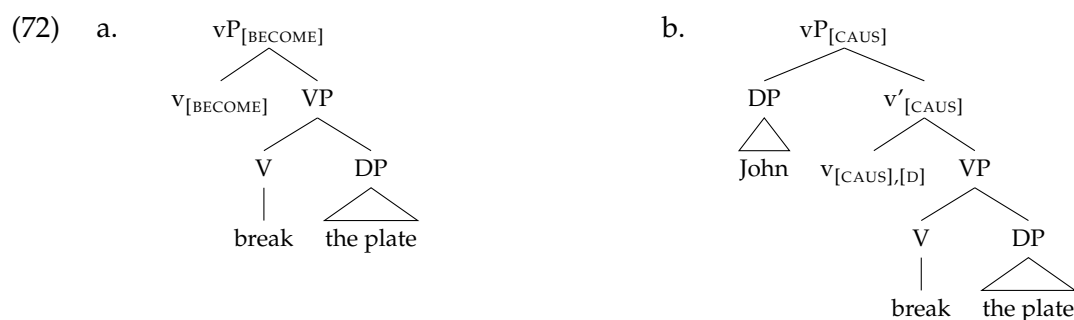
- (69) a. *Joe was murdered, but we don't know who. (Merchant 2013: 81)
 b. *Someone murdered Joe, but we don't know who by.
- (70) a. This can freeze. Please freeze this. (Merchant 2013: 96)
 b. This can freeze. *Please do. (Merchant 2013: 97, from Johnson 2004: 7)

Now, the illicitness of active-passive mismatches such as (69) can be accounted for under the featural non-distinctness approach to the SIC, on the standard assumption that verbs in the active and passive voice have distinct feature values of the Voice head—ACT and PASS (e.g., Merchant 2013, Ranero 2021). Evidence that the value of the Voice head is responsible for the unacceptability of (69) comes from the fact that active-passive mismatches are allowed in English if the ellipsis targets a portion of the structure smaller than Voice, for example vP (71); see also Stockwell 2024 for a recent discussion. Assuming the SIC is stated in terms of featural non-distinctness, the contrasting acceptability of active-passive mismatches in TP and vP ellipsis is fully expected if active and passive are distinct features on Voice, but not if only one member of {active, passive} were featurally marked (for example, if passive were marked with a feature PASS on Voice, while the active simply lacked that feature).

- (71) This problem was to have been looked into, but obviously nobody did.
 (Merchant 2013: 90)

The apparent issue for a featural non-distinctness approach is (70): If mismatches are allowed in the K'iche' antipassive-active context, understood now as a transitivity

alternation, then why is the mismatch with the transitivity alternation in (70) impossible? For starters, the inchoative-causative alternation in (70) is not exactly parallel to the alternation we saw in K'iche', despite the fact that we could characterize both as transitivity alternations. While I showed that the K'iche' AP/active transitive mismatch revolves around the syntactic presence or absence of the internal argument, recent analyses of the inchoative-causative alternation (at least in familiar languages) do not analyze it as involving merely the presence/absence of the external argument, but instead as involving two quite distinct structures. Specifically, in recent constructionist analyses, certain argument structure alternations have been argued to be encoded via different “flavors” of *v* (i.e., the fact that *v* can have a number of different feature specifications): DO, CAUS, and BECOME. These flavors of *v* have distinct distributional patterns and interpretations at the interfaces (Marantz 1997, Harley 1999, 2005 2008, Folli and Harley 2005, 2007). Folli and Harley (2005) suggest that the inchoative-causative alternation in English is due to the ability of certain roots/Vs to combine equally well with *v*[CAUS] and *v*[BECOME]. Each flavor of *v* is associated with a distinct structural configuration; (72a) is an inchoative construction and (72b) a causative construction.²⁰



If inchoative and causative verbs have the structures given in (72), we can immediately see why such mismatches are disallowed under ellipsis: An inchoative-causative mismatch involves a feature clash (due to the features CAUS vs. BECOME on *v*). Such constructions are then correctly predicted to be unable to mismatch under ellipsis on a featural non-distinctness approach to the SIC. This is only the case, however, if the above analysis of the inchoative-causative alternation is justifiable and the same level of empirical coverage cannot be achieved under the simpler analysis that revolves around the presence/absence of the external argument. Indeed, distinct featural specification on *v* is necessary in driving the inchoative-causative alternation because only certain roots/Vs can be inserted under *v*BECOME, accounting for why there is no causative version of *arrive* or *descend*, for example. The same is true for *v*CAUS. An approach that simply posits the presence or absence of [D] on *v* or Voice

²⁰I use the notation from Folli and Harley 2005, 2007; *V* is equivalent to $\sqrt{}$. Moreover, nothing would change if we assumed the external argument of causatives is introduced by Voice and not *v*CAUS: Voice would be specified to select *v*CAUS but not *v*BECOME.

(selecting the external argument) to drive the alternation would not be able to account for this “pickiness” and would massively overgenerate (see [Folli and Harley 2005](#) for a detailed discussion of this issue). With the alternative hypothesis discarded, we can then understand that inchoative-causative mismatches are disallowed under ellipsis because they involve a feature mismatch.

It is also important to note that the analysis of K’iche’ antipassive-active mismatches, where the only distinction is in the presence/absence of the internal argument, does not overgenerate. This is because all transitive verbs have antipassive counterparts (?: 79). Hence, the syntactic distinction between the two can simply be encoded via the presence/absence of [D] and [ERG] features on *v* and Voice. If these features are present, the result is an active transitive form of the verb. If they are absent, the result is the AP. This does not, of course, mean that all fully productive alternations can be captured with privative features. Kaqchikel’s AP-active alternation is a case in point. While all transitive verbs in Kaqchikel have AP counterparts as well, we have seen that their underlying structure is quite different. Capturing the distributional properties of the Kaqchikel AP (independently of ellipsis) requires one to postulate features that clash with features of active transitives (recall [TR] and [ITR] on *v*).

A point similar to the one made for “transitivity alternations” can be made about reflexives of the Romance and Slavic variety. So-called *se*-reflexives in these languages, exemplified in (73) for Italian and Bosnian-Croatian-Serbian (BCS), pattern in a number of ways with intransitive verbs, a discovery that goes back to [Kayne 1975](#). On the other hand, their counterparts with the full anaphoric DP ‘self’ (74) behave like regular transitives.

- (73) a. *Si* *pettina*.
 REFL.CL.3 combs
 ‘She combs herself.’
 b. *Marija se* *češlja*.
 Mary REFL.CL.3 combs
 ‘Mary combs herself.’
- (74) a. *Pettina sé stessa*.
 combs herself
 ‘She combs herself.’
 b. *Marija češlja seb-e*.
 Mary combs self.3-ACC
 ‘Mary combs herself.’

Hence, if only *SE*-reflexives in these languages constitute “true” reflexive constructions, analyzed as instantiating a reflexive flavor of Voice, Voice_{REFL} ([Bruening 2006](#), [Labelle 2008](#), [Déchaine and Wiltschko 2017](#), a.o.), we predict they

should not be able to mismatch with active transitive verbs under ellipsis. Moreover, if full DP reflexives are regular internal arguments which appear in active transitive constructions, we predict that they should be able to be antecedents for active transitive verbs under ellipsis. This prediction is borne out, as evidenced in (75) for Italian and in (76) for BCS.

- (75) a. Pettina *sé stessa* e non so chi altro <pettina>.
 combs herself and NEG know who else combs
 ‘She combs herself and I don’t know who else.’
- b. **Si* pettina e non so chi altro <pettina>.
 REFL.CL.3 combs and NEG know who else combs
intended: ‘She combs herself and I don’t know who else’
- (76) a. Marija češlja *seb-e*, ali ne znam koga još <Marija češlja>.
 Mary combs self.3-ACC but NEG know who else Mary combs
 ‘Mary combs herself, but I don’t know who else.’
- b. *Marija *se* češlja, ali ne znam koga još <Marija češlja>.
 Mary REFL.CL.3 combs but NEG know who else Mary combs
intended: ‘Mary combs herself, but I don’t know who else.’

It therefore seems that mismatches, including argument structure mismatches, are allowed in ellipsis contexts so long as they do not involve feature clashes. Finally, argument-alternations, like voice alternations, can have quite different underlying structures in different languages.

4.2 Theories of features

The SIC argued for here has consequences for theories of syntactic features. While some researchers have argued that a syntax with only privative features should be the default assumption, others have argued that both privative and non-privative features are necessary (see [Cowper and Hall 2014](#) for discussion). Privative features can only be present or absent, whereas non-privative features involve structured oppositions, either as binary values (e.g., [+/-F]) or as values of a higher-order feature, as in multivalued representations of the form [attribute: value]. Selectional features (e.g., [D]) and case features (e.g., [ERG]) are often analyzed as privative.

If the SIC requires featural non-distinctness, it provides a new argument against theories that employ only privative features. Under a privative feature system, a mismatch between an active and a passive clause could be represented as [Act] versus [Pass]. Since neither feature is shared, there is no clash: each structure simply contains a feature that the other lacks. Such a mismatch would therefore be predicted to satisfy the SIC and be acceptable under ellipsis. By contrast, if voice is represented as a binary [+/-Act] or with a multivalued feature, with values such as [Voice: Act] and

[Voice: Pass], the two structures contain incompatible values of the same feature and therefore clash. The SIC predicts such mismatches to be illicit. More generally, if all syntactic features were privative, and given the SIC based on featural non-distinctness, we would not expect any identity violations if all the roots in the derivation were identical, contrary to fact.

The argument against exclusively privative feature systems is not entirely novel. For example, [Harbour \(2011\)](#) argues that privative features are insufficient to capture the complexity of number systems such as that of Kiowa. Likewise, [Adger and Svenonius \(2011: 7\)](#) discuss limitations of privative feature representations arising from their inability to define the natural classes required in theories of locality and (defective) intervention. However, if the version of the SIC defended here is correct, it provides positive evidence that both privative and non-privative features are necessary in the syntax. Mismatches involving the presence versus absence of a privative feature are tolerated, whereas mismatches involving incompatible values of the same feature are not. In principle, ellipsis may also help determine which kinds of non-privative representations are required. Binary ([+/-]) features necessarily involve two values, whereas multivalued features permit larger paradigms. Consequently, if future research were to identify a domain in which three or more feature values consistently pattern as mutually incompatible under ellipsis, this would constitute evidence for multivalued representations. More generally, if the proposal advanced here is correct, ellipsis may provide a valuable diagnostic for investigating the formal architecture of syntactic feature systems.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, I showed that the Mayan language K'iche' allows apparent voice mismatches (antipassive-active) in clausal ellipsis contexts. I then that the antipassive (AP) verb form differs from the active transitive not in Voice specification, but in that it completely lacks the internal argument. I proposed that the ellipsis facts can be accounted for under an approach to syntactic identity in ellipsis which requires featural non-distinctness, but not under approaches that require strict featural identity.

More broadly, I argued that ellipsis can provide a window into the feature composition of syntactic structure. The comparison between K'iche' and the closely related language Kaqchikel showed that constructions which appear superficially similar may differ substantially in their underlying representation. Although both languages possess an AP construction, only the K'iche' AP participates in the relevant mismatch under ellipsis, suggesting a difference in feature composition that I showed is reflected in their argument structure and morphosyntactic behavior. More generally, the paper showed that labels such as *voice* and *argument structure alternation* do not necessarily correspond to uniform syntactic configurations across languages. The

availability of mismatches under ellipsis therefore provides a useful source of evidence for distinguishing between superficially similar structures and uncovering differences in their underlying feature composition.

Finally, I argued that the SIC defended in this paper has direct consequences for our understanding of syntactic features and their organization into featural systems. Specifically, both privative and non-privative features are necessary in the syntax, and research on feature mismatches under ellipsis may prove valuable in determining whether the non-privative features are equipollent or multivalued (or both).

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